A Game of Chess

By Garrison Keillor

NOTE: Listen to Garrison Keillor's Prairie Companion performance of this poem at the following link http://prairiehome.publicradio.org/programs/2011/10/08/videos/#video-1

CAUTION: This selection is available in audio format only - may not be suitable for competition in some states

Ledgend of Players who provide script and sound effects for performance:

GK: Garrison Keillor
TR: Tim Russell
SS: Sue Scotland
TK: Tom Keith

GK: I've lost some of life's battles,

I've known defeat and distress,

But I've not met defeat quite so grim and complete

As when I lost to Freddie at chess.

I've been dissed, dismissed, and demoted

I've even been dumped, I confess,

But never disgraced, demeaned and debased,

Until I lost to Freddie at chess.

He is eleven, my grandson,

And he's played a year or less.

And I'll never forget the day that he said:

TR (KID): Grandpa-----You want to play chess?

GK: I'm sort of busy today, I said.

And then he asked me again.

And he set up the board on the living room floor

And we sat down and set up our men. (SFX)

INTRODUCTION

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He advanced up the middle and soon my bishop

Was caught in a three-way trap. (**TK BRIT**: Dear me!)

I sent out a knight to join in the fight

And he got shot in the kneecap. (**TR**: CRY OF PAIN)

My bishop stood in confusion.

TK: Oh dear, what a pickle.

GK: he said.

TK: O Lord lift thine arm and preserve me from harm

GK: And Freddie lopped off his head. (**TK**: SHUDDER, LOP, PLOP)

I castled my king to protect him

And I cautiously put forth a pawn. (**TK** TIMOROUS PAWN)

And in rode his knight (GALLOPING) in open daylight

And my other bishop was gone. (**TR** BRIT CRY, SPEARING, **TR** FALLS)

(**TK** AND **TR** MOUTH TRUMPETS, BATTLE SFX, HORSES, BATTLE MUSIC)

We fought it out in the middle,

We fought it out on the side,

Men in the saddle rode into the battle,

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One after the other they died.

The air was filled with anguish,

You could hear the bagpipes cry (BAGPIPES)

The battleground shook from the march of the rook (**TR:** GUTTURAL YELL)

And his knights went galloping by. (SFX)

My queen sat calmly knitting

Protected by two loyal pawns,

TR BRIT LADY: What's all that shooting and shouting and hooting

Out on our royal lawns?

We do not choose to lower ourself

To engage in such crude pursuits----

I'll stay right here, and ignore them, oh dear,

Such uncouth uncivilized brutes.

TK: Excuse me, ma'am. It's me. Your left rook.

TR BRIT LADY: Yes? Pray tell, what is it?

Don't pester me when it's time for my tea---

TK: It's another queen, ma'am, come to visit.

GK: The other queen rode across the board (MOTORCYCLE)

She was not what you'd call polite.

She wore a T-shirt that said, "Eat my dirt,"

Her pants were pink, sequinned, and tight.

A cigarette dangled from her lower lip,

And she carried a six-pack of beer.

An axe and two knives and two .45s

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On a long leather bandolier.

She was short and fat and ugly,

And she yelled with all her might:

SS COCKNEY: Come out of your tower, you big fat coward,

Get your butt on the field and fight!

GK: She planted herself in my queen's face

With only a pawn in between.

TR BRIT: Who is that slut on the horse, tut, tut,

She certainly is no queen.

Her hair is a mess, and that fishmonger's voice!

And her manners --- my, my --- she is rough.

Go see to her, rook, and tell her I'll brook

No insults from her, no insolent---- (TR STRANGULATION)

GK: And my queen fell flat on her back,

With the other queen's foot on her neck,

And she scratched and grinned and she broke wind (SFX)

As Freddie whispered---

TR KID: Check.

GK: I looked at my king and he looked at me---

TR BRIT DOLT: Oh dear--- In check? --- oh my.

Well, it doesn't look good but maybe I could

Find a way to play to a tie.

TR DOLT:

Or maybe that pawn could run to the end

And then be promoted to queen.

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I'm sure we've not lost, but at least, at all cost,

One must remain serene.

GK: And he stood there serene and regal and proud

As the enemy queen stood and laughed (**SS** LAUGHTER)

As proud as could be, and my monarchy

Was feeling understaffed.

A lowly pawn (**TK**) and a miserable knight (**TR**)

And a rook made up our crew. (**TK**)

TR DOLT: It looks rather gloomy, but come, rally to me,

And we'll figure out what to do.

(TR KING DITHERING)

GK: And he brought out his charts and studied his books

And he muttered:

TR: Ahem. Let me see.

The hypotenuse squared by the root of the hair

Of the dog times X over 3.

And carry the two, and divide by Y----

GK: And the handsome royal face

Was very concerned, as he carefully turned

And moved himself back one space.

And the pawn said--- **TK**: Brilliant!

GK: the knight said:

TR: Superb!

GK: And the rook said...

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TK: Beautiful, sir.

GK: And the king said...

TR: My boy, it's a little known ploy

That is known as the Spanish spur.

It was used by grandmaster Peter O'Bleness

In 1978,

When it seemed he had lost----

GK: And then the King paused,

And Freddie said.....

TR: Checkmate.

GK: And his queen moved four spaces back (**SS**: CHUCKLE)

GK: Killing the rook with one blow (KONK, TK DEATH),

And the king looked around at the bloody ground

And there simply was no place to go.

TR DOLT: Impossible! Why---- it cannot be.

I'll escape ---- I'll find a route!

GK: And the queen said:

SS: Oh yeah? You think so? Ha! Give up, ya big galoot.

TR DOLT: If I only could think--- I must persevere---

Dear me----- a route of escape----

SS: Throw down your sword and kneel on the board

And kiss my foot, ya big ape.

TR DOLT: I must not give up ---- my army is scattered ---

I simply have to regroup it.

SS: Hey, king! kiss my foot---- it's over, kaput,

What's wrong with you? you stupid?

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GK: My head felt strangely empty

It seemed like a terrible joke.

My king was alone on his tiny throne

Awaiting the final stroke. (TR DOLT)

GK: I said, "Look--- there's a polar bear out on the lawn!"

But Freddie did not blink his eyes.

I guess he had learned you should never turn

Your back on somebody who lies.

My king was dazed----

TR DOLT: Oh well--- toodle-ooo

I surrender.

GK: He said with a sigh.

And the queen yelled,

SS: Whee---hoo! Boogers on you!

GK: And she looked up and spit in my eye. (**SS**: SPIT)

SS: Let's play again. What do you say?

You want to be black or white?

Let's play again soon ----this afternoon----

Or after supper tonight.

GK: And later my king said,

TR DOLT: I've thought of a move

I'm sure would have won the day----

Look here--- if this pawn had not stopped but gone on---

Things would have turned out okay.

GK: I've dreamed of that game over and over

Of the child who says.....

TR: Can we play?

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GK: And the battle roar (TUMULT) and the blood and the gore (SWACK, EUUUU)

As the bodies are carried away (SFX).....

A game of Parchesi is gentle and easy

Or Uno or Sorry, my, yes.

And Monopoly is okay by me

But I do not play Freddie at chess.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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